

If You're Happy and You Know It...

October 23rd, 1966

"Dear God, you sure made a lot of nothing." I muttered in a trance. I'll tell you, once you pass that tenth sign reminding you you're still on "Interstate 77" you really stop thinking it's such a lucky number. At least the radio kept me company with all that singing,

"Something in your eyes was so inviting. Something in your smile was so exciting. Something in your heart told me I must have you! Strangers in the night! Two lonely people..." And, well, when you heard that, you just had to remember: At least God put Frank Sinatra somewhere in all this nothing.

By song's end, the trees lining the road got thicker and somehow that Interstate spat me out onto gravel. Where in the hell I turned wrong I didn't know, but it hardly mattered. My Impala was gettin' hungry and so was I, and there just so happened to be a little bar not so far up ahead...

I guess the man didn't get too many visitors, 'cause by the time the door chimed he was already smiling. Sitting at a piano just next to the bar, practicing. Down along the bar sat another fellow in a shadow, hunched over his drink as if contemplating it a little too deeply.

The man at the piano played the tune:

"If you're happy and you know it, clap your hands..."

Just as he got to the end of the verse I clapped my hands twice.

"Good!" He said, looking at the keys. "It's always good to be happy. What can I getcha?"

"I suppose I'm here on business first and maybe a stiff drink second, iffen you don't mind." I told him, tapping around my pockets till I found the papers in the back of my pants.

"I ain't got nowhere to be!" he said.

"Oh, I'm glad. You see, I'm something of a private detective and I'm afraid I'm being paid to run all over God's creation lookin' for something God just didn't create. But, I figure... well, I might as well do their money's worth of lookin'." I told him.

"Aw shucks! They got you on one of them goose chases do they? Well, a dollar's a dollar ain't it? What's this nothin' you looking for?" he said, all too happy to help.

I unfolded a few of the papers.

"Well, there's just been a few odd reports right around this area and they wanted me to look into it..." I said, and he just kept on smilin'.

"For instance, this first one comes from a couple of kids, really. They were out playin' catch and hittin' balls when in the distance they see the silhouette of a man. And so, the kids, they run out towards the silhouette. Nothing too odd 'bout that, but they say the closer they got, it never stopped being a silhouette. They say they could hear it chuckle before they could see the

face that was chucklin'." I told the man at the piano, and looked over to the man down the bar. He didn't even look my way once.

"Well ain't that just somethin'." The grinning man said in an amused tone. "I tell you, dem children dese days got more ideas than a hound dog has fleas!" Then he went back to looking down again towards those keys and repeating the piano verse he'd been practicing.

"Yeah." I replied over the piano tune, just as it hit the "and you know it" part. "Only bit of trouble is... their daddy's been missing for about a week now." I said as he finished the verse. In the silence, he stomped his feet twice to the beat.

"So I hope you don't mind me askin', but you ain't seen nothing suspicious 'round here, 'ave ya?"

"Oh no, not me!" he said. "You haven't seen nothin' either, has you Johnny?" He looked down at the man along the bar. At the question, the man's head bobbed down, as if he were noddin' off to sleep. Then it stopped and lifted back up to its original position.

"Yes?" I said to the man down the bar. "Was that a 'Yes you has', or a 'Yes you hasn't' seen anything strange recently?" I asked.

"Johnny hasn't seen nothin' either." The grinning man translated. "Pardon him. I think I might've served 'im one too many drinks. The drinks started stiff and now so is he!" He said, chuckling to himself.

"Maybe you served him too many and me not enough?" I said, taking a seat at the bar and gesturing for him to join. "You know, I grew up hearing another version of that song you've been playin'. Different lyrics to the same tune."

"Is that right?" He said, grinning that big ol' grin. In the light I could see his dark eyes were only pupils and his flesh so pale it could be mistaken for dead.

"Put a whiskey on the rocks and I'll tell it to ya." I said. He only answered with that same smile while he turned to fetch the whiskey. As he grabbed the bottle, I reached down into my boot and grasped the hilt of a long-edged knife from within my boot. He poured my drink.

"I think it went..." I said to him standing to walk down the bar, holding the knife beneath the bar and the whiskey above it.

"O', be careful little eyes what you see. O', be careful little eyes what you see. For the Father up above is looking down in love, so be careful little eyes what you see." I told him, taking a swig of my drink. "I'll ask one last time. Are you sure those little eyes of yours ain't seen nothin'?" As I finished the sentence I'd reached Johnny.

"I'd like to think my little eyes would've told me iffen they'd seen anything! But y'know, I think I liked the other version of that song better!" He said.

"Really? You ain't seen nothing?" I said, and I reached up with my knife and cut a thin string coming out of Johnny's skull. His head dropped to the table with a thump, and soon after the body fell from the chair entirely.

"Something tells me..." I told him, looking up from the deadman. "That the Lord ain't lookin' down on you with love." I said. He chuckled at that statement too.

“Well, you see, I just might be in his blindspot!” It said, laughin’, and his grin continued to contort as if his smile were elastic. “You can me Indrid. It’s such a *pleasure* to meet you!” he said and stuck a hand out over the bar lookin’ to shake. Beady eyes stared at me as I walked back to him, he just waited and his smile kept creeping upwards till its edges were up to his nose.

When I reached him, I extended the hand with the knife in it, as if to shake. But I didn’t bother with the introduction. I brought the blade up quick as I could into the man’s neck. It entered like a stick in mud, and I drove it across in a crescent shape through the resinous flesh of his neck until he stepped back pulling the knife along with him. The thing stumbled back into the wall, shaking the various bottles behind him. The knife plopped from his throat to the ground carrying droplets of pale flesh.

“Oh my!” Indrid said, but his mouth didn’t move. Instead his head hinged back and the hole in his neck spoke the words. “I guess I’m twice as happy now,” He said, the wound forming a grin of its own.

“Now I’ve really got to show it.”

Indrid dragged the body back behind the bar, beaming it back to his people. Before it burst into immaterial, he threw a note on its back:

“This One is an empty planet. Devoid of intelligence. I suspect that the very emptiness of this land has crept its way into their brains. But I must concede... They do make good music! And I am *ever* so fond of this thing they like to call ‘*Southern Hospitality*’.”